StateGrown

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WEST VIRGINIA STATE UNIVERSITY

StateGrown

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ON THE COVER: George Patterson, owner of Hernshaw Farms and cold storage program participant, poses with his mushrooms.

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BORLAUG SCHOLAR

BIOTECHNOLOGY GRAD STUDENT WINS HIGHLY COMPETITIVE AWARD

Graduate student Dinesh Ghimire was selected by the National Association of Plant Breeders (NAPB) to receive the Borlaug Scholars Award in May 2022.

This year's recipients consist of seven undergraduate students, two master's degree students and 14 graduate students from across the country. The award is highly competitive and includes a one-year NAPB membership and registration to the NAPB Annual Meeting at Iowa State University in Ames, Iowa, which Ghimire attended in August 2022.

"I learned about different kinds of research conducted in the field of plant breeding throughout various regions of the U.S.," he said. "I also gained valuable knowledge about the importance of networking in the scientific community and technical skills of preparing and giving scientific presentations."

The NAPB Borlaug Scholars Program strengthens the plant breeding profession by helping to support the attendance of future leaders at the NAPB Annual Meeting. The program targets upper-level undergraduate and advanced graduate students, each of which paired up with an NAPB mentor committed to the recipient's professional development.

"Through the mentoring program, I learned the importance of excelling in the research community through collaborative works and seeking a career in a field that genuinely piques my interest," Ghimire said. "This whole experience has motivated and helped me find new ways to achieve my career goals effectively."

The NAPB is a grass-roots, volunteer-run organization that engenders support and raises public awareness for plant breeding work and advances excellence in research, education and outreach in plant improvement.

"As an undergraduate student, I was inspired by Dr. Norman E. Borlaug to pursue a career in plant breeding," said Ghimire. "I want to help farmers and combat our global food security issues."

He also credits his mentor and advisor, Dr. Barbara Liedl, for guiding and supporting him in his journey.

"Dinesh is not only the first WVSU student to be named a Borlaug Scholar by the NAPB, but he is the first student at a Historically Black College or University (HBCU) or 1890 land-grant university to receive this award," Liedl said.

Ghimire will graduate from WVSU in May 2023 with a master's degree in biotechnology and plans to earn his Ph.D. in plant breeding.

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